STRATEGIC ACCOUNTS

SAOS Leader Guide

Rollout and coaching guide for strategic account leaders

ACCOUNT SELECTION

OPERATING DISCIPLINE

EXECUTIVE TRUST

Contents

The handbook follows the SAOS conversation from purpose and mindset through the practical sections used in account planning.

Purpose

What SAOS is and why strategic account planning needs its own discipline.

This guide is for managers, directors, and executive sponsors responsible for rolling out, inspecting, coaching, and sustaining the Strategic Account Operating System.

The user handbook explains how an individual contributor should think through the account. This leader guide explains how to turn that thinking into a team standard.

The Rollout Conversation

When introducing SAOS to the team, emphasize that this is not a compliance exercise. It is a coaching system.

Suggested rollout framing:

> SAOS is how we turn our best account instincts into a repeatable operating system. It helps us choose the right accounts, understand why they would change, map who matters, design the first wedge, and build momentum with discipline. The goal is not to fill every box perfectly. The goal is to expose the strategy, the gaps, and the next best move.

Operating Cadence

Weekly Strategic Account Review

Use SAOS to inspect a small number of priority accounts.

Recommended agenda:

1. Account Snapshot: why does this account deserve focus?
2. The Big Play: why would they change now?
3. Influence Mapping: who matters and where is access weak?
4. Account Expansion: what is the wedge and what does it unlock?
5. Relationship Timeline: what changed since last review?
6. 30 / 60 / 90 Plan: what are we doing and what does the customer owe us?

Monthly Portfolio Review

Use SAOS across accounts to identify:

- Tier 1 accounts without economic buyers
- High-potential accounts with weak Big Plays
- Accounts with strong activity but weak signals
- Accounts with no clear expansion path
- Accounts where the incumbent moat is underestimated
- Accounts that need executive sponsorship from GPC

Pre-Call Preparation

Before important customer meetings, review:

- The Big Play
- The Blindspots
- The specific Entry Point for each person attending
- Current momentum signals
- Desired customer commitment

Post-Call Discipline

After important meetings, log:

- What changed
- What we learned
- New stakeholders
- New pain
- Customer commitments
- Momentum score
- Next move

Coaching Questions By Section

Use these questions in manager 1:1s, deal reviews, and team workshops.

Account Snapshot:

- Why this account?
- Why now?
- Is this truly strategic or just large?

The Big Play:

- What is broken in the status quo?
- What happens if they do nothing?
- Why is GPC uniquely credible?

Competing Priorities:

- What internal tradeoff explains the decision?
- Which group is pulling in which direction?

The Blindspots:

- What assumption could kill this pursuit?
- What question must we answer next?

Influence Mapping:

- Who is our champion?
- Who is the economic buyer?
- Who can block us?
- Who coaches us when we are not in the room?

Account Expansion:

- What is the first wedge?
- What trust does it create?
- What does it unlock?

The Battlefield:

- Why is the incumbent still there?
- What makes them vulnerable?
- What proof reduces switching risk?

Strategic Entry Points:

- What does this person care about?
- What is the right message for them?
- What is the next move?

How They Buy:

- How much process friction exists?
- What does the decision path require?
- Do we need a bypass, pilot, or executive sponsor?

30 / 60 / 90 Plan:

- What will we do?
- What must the customer do?
- What proof will exist in 30, 60, and 90 days?

Relationship Timeline:

- What changed?
- Is momentum increasing or just activity?
- What signal proves we are closer to a decision?

Quality Bar

A strong SAOS plan should be:

- Specific: names, dates, triggers, sites, providers, pain, and next moves
- Executive-relevant: written in business language, not product shorthand
- Politically aware: maps influence and access honestly
- Actionable: points directly to the next customer interaction
- Evidence-based: separates assumptions from known facts
- Expansion-minded: starts with the wedge and thinks beyond it
- Current: updated as the account changes

Red Flags

Watch for these signs that a plan is weak:

- The Big Play sounds like a product pitch.
- No economic buyer is identified.
- The champion is just someone who likes us.
- The incumbent is treated as incompetent without evidence.
- The account expansion section is a product menu.
- The 30 / 60 / 90 Plan has no customer commitments.
- The Relationship Timeline is all activity and no signals.
- The same copy appears across multiple entry points.
- Blindspots are vague.
- The plan does not explain why now.

What Good Looks Like

A strong strategic account plan should enable any leader on the team to understand:

- Why the account matters
- Why the account may change
- Where GPC can create differentiated value
- Who must be influenced
- Where the risk is
- What we will do next
- What the customer must do next
- What expansion could become possible

If the plan does that, it is working.

Example: Multi-Location Enterprise Pursuit

Account context:

> Large Nebraska-headquartered organization with multiple operating locations, high public visibility, and a mixed provider environment.

The Big Play:

> Their current network model is too fragmented for the scale and visibility of the business. Branch performance, outage risk, and inconsistent provider accountability are becoming operational issues. GPC can create a more resilient, locally accountable platform that supports growth and reduces escalation pain.

Competing Priority:

> Scale vs. reliability. The organization wants to expand and modernize, but cannot tolerate instability across locations.

Blindspot:

> Who owns the business impact of downtime: IT, operations, finance, or executive leadership?

Influence Map:

> IT director is a potential champion. CFO may be economic buyer. Operations leader feels site-level pain. Procurement controls process. Need bridge from IT to executive sponsor.

Expansion Strategy:

> Start with high-impact locations where backup, dedicated access, or SD-WAN can prove responsiveness and reliability. Use that proof to expand into managed firewall, cloud connectivity, and broader multi-site architecture.

Battlefield:

> Incumbent has familiarity and existing contracts, but support inconsistency and fragmented accountability create vulnerability. GPC should position around local responsiveness, network depth, and managed operational confidence.

30 / 60 / 90:

> 30: Validate outage history, provider map, and decision process.
> 60: Deliver resiliency assessment and site-priority architecture.
> 90: Secure executive review and define phase-one deployment.

Facilitation Guide For Rollout

Opening Discussion

Ask the team:

- What separates a strategic account from a large account?
- Where do we currently rely too much on memory or individual instinct?
- What account knowledge do we lose when it is not written down?
- What makes GPC uniquely credible with Midwest enterprise accounts?

Workshop Exercise

Pick one real Tier 1 account. In groups, answer only three questions:

1. What is The Big Play?
2. Who is the economic buyer and who is the champion?
3. What is the first wedge and what does it unlock?

Then compare answers. If the team disagrees, that is the value of SAOS: it exposes the strategy gap.

Manager Coaching Prompt

Instead of asking, "Did you update the plan?" ask:

> What did the plan teach us this week?

Better follow-ups:

- What changed?
- What did we learn?
- What assumption was wrong?
- What customer commitment did we earn?
- What is now the next best move?

Frequently Asked Questions

Common questions before the rollout conversation.

Is SAOS replacing CRM?

No. CRM remains the system for accounts, contacts, deals, activities, and tactical execution. SAOS is the strategy layer for priority accounts.

Does every account need a full SAOS plan?

No. The deeper the account's value, complexity, or visibility, the more complete the plan should be.

Is it okay if sections are incomplete?

Yes, if the gaps are visible and intentional. An honest blindspot is better than a fake answer.

How often should SAOS be updated?

After meaningful account interactions, before major account reviews, and whenever new information changes the strategy.

Who owns the plan?

The account owner owns it, but the best plans are team artifacts. Specialists, sales engineers, managers, and executive sponsors should all contribute where they have insight.

What belongs in exports?

PDF and PowerPoint exports should tell the strategic story. They intentionally exclude promoted tactical CRM activities unless those activities are rewritten as strategic signals or manual insights.

Open Questions For Rollout

These are not blockers, but they are worth deciding before team launch:

1. What exact tier definitions should the Strategic Accounts team use for Tier 1, Tier 2, and Tier 3?
2. Which accounts are mandatory SAOS accounts on day one?
3. What is the minimum completion expectation before a strategic account review?
4. Who can designate an account as Tier 1?
5. What weekly or monthly cadence will leadership use to inspect SAOS plans?
6. When should GPC executive sponsors be attached to a plan?
7. What examples should we use in rollout: customer names, anonymized accounts, or demo accounts?
8. What fields are required before a plan can be considered "review ready"?

Closing Principle

The simplest standard for strong strategic account plans.

SAOS is not about filling boxes. It is about building strategic judgment.

For GPC, the opportunity is real: we have the network, the local credibility, the managed services portfolio, and the customer-service reputation to win large, visible, complex accounts across the Midwest.

SAOS gives the team a common operating system to pursue those accounts with precision.

The best plans will not be the longest. They will be the clearest.

They will answer:

> Why this account, why change, why now, why GPC, who matters, and what happens next?